Nikshep Kulli

Engineering Leader – AI-Augmented Software Delivery, Java & Cloud-Native Platforms

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Summary

Engineering leader with 8+ years building Java/Spring Boot microservices, cloud-native platforms and CI/CD, now focused on GenAI and AI-augmented software delivery, including shipping a production RAG chatbot. As Co-founder & CTO of Starteryou (15,000+ users, 342 employer partners, $1.2M pre-seed), I set architecture, DevOps and engineering standards for a 12-person team. Earlier, 3 years at Cerner (Oracle Health) building secured Spring Cloud microservices in a regulated healthcare environment. I run AI coding assistants inside day-to-day SDLC workflows, publish NLP/ML research, and have taught graduate data architecture as an Adjunct Professor.

Core Skills

- **GenAI & AI-augmented SDLC:** Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG), LLM chatbots, LLM-assisted development (Claude Code, ChatGPT), prompt engineering, NLP (LDA topic modeling, sentiment analysis, summarization), Hugging Face, spaCy, NLTK, Scikit-learn, Keras, Amazon SageMaker
- **Java & backend:** Java, Spring Boot, Spring Cloud (Eureka, Config Server, Sleuth), Spring Security (OAuth2, JWT), Spring Data JPA, Hibernate, Maven, JUnit, Mockito, Node.js, Python, Django
- **Cloud-native & platform:** AWS (incl. S3), Azure, Docker (multi-stage builds), Kubernetes, Terraform modules for AWS and Azure, multi-environment infrastructure
- **DevOps & developer productivity:** GitHub Actions, Jenkins, CI/CD for web and mobile, GitHub Projects/Issues, Agile, semantic versioning
- **Data & streaming:** PostgreSQL, MongoDB, SQL/PL-SQL, Vertica, Cassandra, Hadoop, Apache Kafka, Airflow, Pandas
- **Frontend & mobile:** React, React Native

Experience

Starteryou Inc. — Co-Founder & Chief Technology Officer Jul 2024 – Nov 2026
New York (Remote)

- Owned technical strategy and architecture for a two-sided student–employer platform; grew to 15,000+ users and 342 employer partners and supported a $1.2M pre-seed raise.
- Led a 12-person cross-functional team (5 engineers, 4 interns, DevOps, UI/UX) with Agile sprints, code-review standards and GitHub Projects.
- Built GitHub Actions CI/CD pipelines across dev and prod, cutting release time by 40%.
- Built and shipped a RAG-based AI assistant (Node.js/Express, Hugging Face LLMs) that grounds answers in Starteryou's job and platform content, helping students and employers with job search, applications, career guidance and platform support.
- Introduced AI coding assistants into the team's development and review workflow to speed up delivery of features and documentation.
- Defined infrastructure-as-code with reusable Terraform modules (AWS and Azure) and multi-stage Docker builds for consistent, smaller, faster deployments.
- Secured the platform: HTTPS/TLS, database encryption and access control, IP allow-listing, Stripe payments with webhook handling.
- Shipped a React Native app (iOS/Android) and a real-time, geolocation-based ride-matching feature.

Organic Mandya — Head of Engineering Jun 2026 – Sep 2026
Bengaluru

- Led engineering for a farm-to-consumer organic food brand, owning the Suggi mobile app and e-commerce platform, and grew the team to 6 engineers.
- Built automated CI/CD for the Android and iOS apps: signing, Firebase config, and Google Play / App Store Connect releases.
- Defined the migration strategy from Shopify to a custom commerce platform.
- Designed an AI-native hiring process: candidates solved live support tickets using Claude, scored on solution depth and quality.
- Created a Forward Deployed Engineer role linking engineering with farmer cooperatives and retail partners.

Sacred Heart University — Adjunct Professor, CSIT Jan 2024 – Dec 2024
Fairfield, CT

- Taught graduate courses including CS 652 Big Data Architecture, MongoDB, NLP/text analytics and C++ data structures; contributed to curriculum development; teaching ratings of 4.5–5.0/5.0.
- Earlier, as Research Assistant (Jan–May 2023): NLP research on COVID-19 social media (LDA, sentiment analysis).

Cerner Corporation (Oracle Health) — Software Engineer II Dec 2019 – Aug 2022
Bengaluru

- Built Spring Boot RESTful microservices with Spring Cloud (Eureka, Config Server, Sleuth) for service discovery, configuration and distributed tracing.
- Secured APIs with Spring Security, OAuth2 and JWT in a regulated healthcare environment; removed sensitive password exposure in the Olympus application.
- Deployed containerized services to Azure and internal cloud; tuned performance with caching and asynchronous processing.
- Built developer tooling: a VS Code plugin for Call Home developers (Associate Behavior Award for Innovate & Simplify) and a Django-based Call Home portal.
- Improved data-collection frameworks (Jetstream CSV reader, Call Home scripts in SQL/PL-SQL/PowerShell) feeding Vertica.
- Maintained quality with JUnit and Mockito test suites across multi-module Maven builds.

Earlier — 6D Technologies & Probots Techno Solutions, Software Engineer Jun 2018 – Nov 2019

- Built Spring Boot CRUD services, a React tree-view component and MSISDN reporting for an SMSC GUI (6D); wrote a C/C++ REST API controlling a kidney-dialysis reprocessing unit and built Android/IoT GPS-tracking apps and RTSP/RTMP streaming (Probots).

Publications, Recognition & Certification

- "The Gambit of De-Dollarization: Unveiling New Currency Frontiers through NLP" — ICCSEA, Oct 2024
- "COVID-19 Vaccine Response on Social Media using LDA Analysis" — Future of Information and Communications Conference, Jun 2023
- Four innovation awards at Cerner, including one for AI-based ventilator-usage optimization (2021); Cerner ShipIt XI, 2nd place (2022) — INGEST, gesture-AI Android app for sign language
- MongoDB certification

Education

- **M.S., Computer Science (Data Science)** — Sacred Heart University, Fairfield, CT · Dec 2023 · GPA 3.9/4.0
- **B.E., Electrical & Electronics Engineering** — M.S. Ramaiah University of Applied Sciences, Bengaluru · Jul 2018
- **Diploma, Electrical & Electronics Engineering** — P.V.P Polytechnic, Bengaluru · May 2014